

Floor Show

Enemy's enemies join hands to corner the Congress in Parliament

- In an unprecedented move, a bill was deferred at the introductory stage.
- No UPA ally joined the Congress in defending the Indo-Pak joint statement.
- The RJD, SP and Left joined the NDA to attack the Congress on the price rise and its Pakistan policy.
- The BSP, the SP and the BJP sank their differences to oppose the Congress over the Bundelkhand issue.

PRIME MINISTER MANMOHAN SINGH WITH THE MINISTERS OF PARLIAMENTARY AFFAIRS—(FROM LEFT) CHAVAN, BANSAL AND NARAYANASAMY

still refuses to forgive him for breaking the alliance in Bihar and Mulayam is hurt at the Congress party's refusal to include him in the Government despite the fact that he bailed out Manmohan over the nuclear deal. The Government's stand on the Ambani brothers' dispute has not endeared it much with the SP leader who stalled two important discussions on the price rise and the Indo-Pak joint statement over it. The Congress, still glowing from the euphoria of its electoral win, is in no mood to placate either of the Yadavs. This despite the fact that the Congress needs both the SP and the RJD to get its bills passed in the Rajya Sabha. As an NCP leader says, "Sometimes they behave as if they have 400-plus MPs instead of 206."

Lack of strong coordination on the floor of the House by the Congress has brought together some rather unusual bedfellows—whether it is the BJP and the Left over the Judges Bill or the BJP, SP and BSP on the proposal to set up a separate Bundelkhand authority. When Mulayam walked out with the NDA and the Left on the Indo-Pak policy, a bemused Lalu looked around and quipped, "What am I doing here", and joined them.

One uproar that could have easily been avoided was the one over Rahul Gandhi's suggestion on Bundelkhand. As the suggestion came from a Congress MP instead of the Government, the Opposition lacked fire to oppose it other than saying that this was infringing on the authority of

the state. However, what sent the matter out of control was Union Coal Minister Sriprakash Jaiswal going a step ahead in claiming that such a body was being set up. This riled the Opposition which alleged that this was now a Government move and against the federal character of the Constitution. Finally, Chavan had to clarify that no such proposal was pending before the Government.

In the previous run of the UPA Government when the Congress was much more dependent on its allies, it had a co-ordination committee and a common minimum programme in place to accommodate their demands. This time round, there is not even the pretence of such a mechanism.

The NCP, a key UPA ally, is upset with the Congress for not firming up an alliance in Maharashtra which is going to the polls soon, even after setting a July 15 deadline. The date came and went without a call from the Congress. The NCP suggestion that they go in for an alliance in Haryana and Arunachal Pradesh as well was dismissed outright. The Congress knows that right now its electoral prospects are brighter than its allies. Less tolerant Mamata Banerjee, the fiery Trinamool leader, almost walked out of a cabinet meeting when the Congress tried to push through the twin Land Acquisition (Amendment) and Relief and Rehabilitation Bills. She was finally placated with the suggestion that her objections would be factored in at the Standing Committee stage.

The Congress, sensing a win in the coming state elections in Maharashtra and Haryana, feels that the SP and the RJD have no other place to go, more so at a time when the Third Front is in a shambles. The same logic applies to current allies. The Congress also feels that the NCP, Trinamool and even the DMK need it, maybe more than it needs them. It is the high of a second consecutive term in power, and a moment that the Congress has waited over two decades for. It is indeed a euphoric moment, but perhaps the Congress will do well to remember that what goes up eventually comes down. ■